

The Claremont City Council held a meeting on Thursday, May 18, 2017, in the Council Chambers of City Hall.

The meeting was called to order by Mayor Lovett at 6:30 p.m.

Members of the Council present were:

Ward I Councilor Carolyn Towle
Ward II Councilor Scott Pope
At-Large Councilor Keith Raymond
Assistant Mayor Victor Bergeron
Mayor Charlene Lovett
At-Large Councilor Allen Damren
At-Large Councilor Bruce Temple
Ward III Councilor Nicholas Koloski
At-Large Councilor John Simonds

Also present were:

Ryan McNutt, City Manager
Jane Taylor, City Solicitor
Mary Walter, Finance Director

AGENDA CHANGES

None

Mayor Lovett said:

- The Rogue Robots Team is leaving tomorrow to compete in the Nationals at Georgia Tech.
- Senator Hassan will be the keynote speaker at River Valley Community College graduation tomorrow.
- Will request to set up an additional Council meeting once all departments have been heard from, so Council can look at the budget as a whole.
- The City Manager had asked for questions from Councilors on the budget and those answers will be included tonight. She and one other Councilor had submitted questions.

BUDGET

Fire

Department Request \$2,789,931 City Manager Proposed \$2,553,805

Fire Chief Rick Bergeron said this budget is being significantly affected by the SAFER (Staffing for Adequate Fire & Emergency Response) grant. The SAFER grant started in March 2014 and was for 3 years. The three SAFER people that were hired are veterans and that saved money on their benefits package, because they stayed on VA (Veterans Administration) benefits. FEMA has granted an extension and advanced the City the balance of the grant to be used in this budget. The City has recently received \$237,591 which reflects the balance from the SAFER grant. It covers some of the current year. Ms. Walter said some of it is for this year and \$170,000 will go toward FY18 and it covers 39 weeks (through the end of next March).

Chief Bergeron said the Fire Department has two shifts of five people each and one shift of four. There are 11 Call Firefighters. There was one retirement and that position was not filled and is not budgeted.

Regarding Rents & Leases and what was given up, Ms. Walter said last year one vehicle didn't get purchased, the money was used to finish the Fire Department's barn. There is very little CIP (Capital Improvements Plan) money in this budget. Ms. Walter said that Engine 2 didn't get replaced.

Chief Bergeron said the work being done on the barn has been pared down. Some items, including two windows, will be on an upcoming CIP.

Regarding Rents & Leases, Chief Bergeron said that Engine 2 is a 37 year old pumper tanker and it could be used in a rural community. His plan was to purchase a new engine identical to #2 in order to balance the maintenance management of the apparatus. It costs about \$500,000 for a new tanker, so he is looking for other options.

Chief Bergeron said they are in pretty good shape with air packs. They purchased 26 in 2014 and the life expectancy is generally 20 years.

Mr. Koloski was concerned about keeping the vehicles longer than they used to. He doesn't want them to be driven until they fall apart.

Mr. McNutt said he wanted to hold the line on vehicles in this budget. There are no new vehicles in this budget.

Chief Bergeron said the rescue truck has the water rescue equipment on it. It was planned to be replaced in 2020. With the current use, he said the life expectancy may be extended.

Hazardous Waste Management – Chief Bergeron said Claremont participates with three other communities. Claremont citizens participate and Claremont pays its share. In 2018, one collection day will be in Claremont. The cost to the host is generally around \$10,000, so he will encumber this year's money to pay that.

Mr. Temple asked about making a tentative approval of the budget. Mayor Lovett said she doesn't want to do it because one budget was tabled and she wants to look at the budget globally. There is a possibility of change.

There was a discussion about traffic lights. Chief Bergeron said there is a problem at the North and Elm Streets intersection. The repair is \$4,500-\$5,000 and he only has \$2,400 left in that line. Traffic light repairs can be expensive. He responded to Mayor Lovett's question about the gasoline/diesel line item and he said that could be lowered.

Airport

Department Request \$89,778.00

City Manager Proposed \$89,778.00

Chief Bergeron said fuel prices are reasonably competitive at \$3.99. Newport is consistently lower (9 cents/gallon).

Mr. McNutt said the City is working toward getting a café at the airport which would make it more of a destination.

Chief Bergeron said the fuel storage is underground; upgrades are made annually; inspections are made regularly; and DES (Department of Environmental Services) rules are reviewed annually. The tank is relatively new and he checks it weekly.

Chief Bergeron said the new hangar is expected to be completed by the end of June. It is a community hangar that will house 5-6 planes. It will replace the current community hangar.

Chief Bergeron said the timeline for the new terminal building is to demolish the old building before next winter. They will use a temporary construction office building for the terminal building and will construct a new building next summer.

Water

Department Request \$2,252,742.00

City Manager Proposed \$2,246,736.00

Scott Sweet, Public Works Director, said insurance went up and Regular Pay is down due to retirement(s). He gave a brief overview of his department's expenses. Rice Reservoir is out for bid and will start in June/July. White Water spillway is being worked on.

Ms. Walter said she is usually conservative with revenues.

Ms. Walter said water revenues received when North Country Smokehouse comes online will reduce the amount of money to be taken out of retained earnings. Administrative Costs were increased due to health benefits increases and retirement increases.

Council discussed chargeback to the General Fund for administrative tasks not done by water/sewer employees and whether it was correct.

Ms. Walter said if the bid for Main Street is not awarded by June 30th, then that money will be encumbered.

Mr. Sweet said Rents & Leases – Vehicle Schedule is for replacing a backhoe.

Sewer

Department Request \$2,646,336.00

City Manager Proposed \$2,632,648.00

Mr. Temple asked about Contract WWTP – Addl Services which is for long term maintenance and repairs. He asked Mr. Sweet why so little has been spent. Mr. Sweet will contact the contractor.

Mr. Sweet said Capital Projects is for the Ascutney Street separation. Public Works' priorities turned to lead line removal, so they didn't get to that. He will encumber the money.

Mr. Temple asked about the water meters and sanitary sewer meters. Victor St. Pierre, Assistant Public Works Director, said they added sewer meters, so they split that between water and sewer meters. The project originally was \$1 million over five years. They are replacing flat rate water meters. They are coming in 30% under the \$1 million budget. They expect to get most done this coming year. They have 1,100 of 3,500 meters changed. This year's money will allow them to change another third. The new meters (radio read program) cut down the time it takes to read them from seven days with two people to one day with one person.

Mayor Lovett said the water rates were recently raised and it was agreed to review them annually. She thinks once that assessment comes back, it might be a good idea to review that and the sewer rates.

Sanitation

Department Request \$183,435.00

City Manager Proposed \$180,430.00

Mr. Sweet said there are two full-time employees on Tuesday and Saturday and the part-time person mows the lawn. The full-time people collect the City's trash on Wednesday which is billed to the Highway department.

Mr. Sweet said this year 315 tons of solid waste was received, 247 tons recycling and 96 tons of C&D (construction and demolition). They changed contractors and by going from zero-sort recycling to separating the recycling, saved \$17,000. Mayor Lovett gave credit for that to the Transfer Station Ad Hoc Committee for encouraging that change.

Mr. Koloski asked about the stickers/permits. Ms. Walter said it is hard to track users by the number of stickers. You can get a sticker for each vehicle, and many people have more than one vehicle. Every time you trade a vehicle, you get a new sticker. Mr. Koloski said this was supposed to be a measuring device. Mayor Lovett said the primary reason to institute the stickers was to keep non-Claremonters out of the Transfer Station because Casella's costs were higher. Mr. Koloski is curious to know the total number of users.

Mr. Sweet said the attendants believe it to be 700-800 users.

Ms. Lovett said the true cost of running the Transfer Station is not as significant as initially thought. To privatize, the savings would be negligible.

Mr. McNutt agreed this would be negligible. If you privatize, the City would find more dumping along the roads. He would rather have another year to evaluate this and revisit it in FY19.

Mr. Koloski asked about putting solar there. Ms. Walter said we don't have three-phase power there and getting it there would be expensive.

Cemetery

Department Request \$242,711.00

City Manager Proposed \$205,779.00

Preservation of Cemetery Records – Mr. Sweet said that is completed except for a couple of small deed books. Mr. Bergeron suggested bringing some of the books that have been done for the Council to look at.

Mr. Raymond asked about Capital – Cemetery Gate. Mr. Sweet said that is for the Main Street entrance to the cemetery and they are having a hard time finding a mason to commit to that. They have \$2,500 and will encumber that.

Mr. Sweet said he may have to do a line item transfer from Building & Vehicle M&Rs to cover overtime due to Saturday burials.

Mr. Sweet said Land M&R/Cemetery Property Improve will cover the cost to remove two nearly dead maple trees next to the cemetery on West Pleasant Street.

Mr. Sweet said overall, he has the resources that are needed in this budget.

Streets & Roads (Highways)

Department Request \$3,695,910.00

City Manager Proposed \$2,750,577.00

Mr. Sweet said for the Citizen Street Bridge, the inlet slopes are failing. Engineers are working on a plan now. He will encumber this year's money and with next year's money, he hopes to have enough to do the work.

Mr. Sweet said there are 15 full-time highway people, except Monday and Tuesdays (2 are at the Transfer Station). He is hiring summer help and there is a part-time janitor.

Mr. Temple asked about Whitewater Brook Road and East Street culverts. Mr. Sweet said Whitewater is designed and East Street is being designed now. Regarding Whitewater, Mr. Temple asked about making it a one-way bridge. Mr. Sweet said the designer is looking at a bridge instead of a box culvert. Ms. Walter said the actual cost may come in less. Mr. Sweet thinks it may come in around \$50,000 to \$70,000 and if so, he can do a couple other culverts such as Bible Hill. He chose East Street because of the TAP grant money for East Street sidewalk improvements.

Mr. Temple asked if Bible Hill is more critical than the twin culverts on Washington Street. Mr. Sweet said yes. Bible Hill is caving in.

Mr. Koloski asked since there is no money for paving, what other projects will be done. Mr. Sweet said the Main Street project should be started this fall; Safe Routes to Schools, Belding and Middle Streets; Rails to Trails (sidewalks) on East Street; and Bowen Street intersection this fall. Main Street will involve road work from Opera House Square to Leo's Market. He will encumber money this year and there is earmarked money.

Mr. Damren said he was disappointed there was not money in the budget for road paving.

Mr. McNutt said there needs to be a more thought-out plan to maintain paved roads. He has asked Mr. Sweet to get a professional pavement category index survey done. That could be done for \$50,000-\$70,000. It would give us a rating of all of our roads. We could use the information to prioritize the roads. He said he has received requests for road repairs, but most are lightly traveled.

Councilors expressed their concerns about the road work not being done. Mayor Lovett is against bonding for road work. Bonding can't take the place of putting money in the budget for roads.

Mr. Koloski is concerned that Washington Street is deteriorating. With nothing in the budget, the City is setting the stage to have to go out for a bond again.

Mr. Sweet talked about his plan. He acknowledged that Washington Street and Main Street need work.

Mr. Temple said last year he specifically asked to put some money into an analysis plan that was data driven. At the time, Council didn't feel it was necessary. He talked about the road by the Elks Club and the sewer going out to Stevens High School. He said we need a data-driven plan to do the streets.

Mr. McNutt would like to see a plan. There is very little state aid. He's looking to the federal government to see if anything is available.

Mr. Bergeron agreed money is needed for the roads, but Council has been afraid to raise taxes, so the money was not added to the budget.

Mr. Pope suggested to crack-seal and chip seal the roads to at least preserve what we have.

Mr. McNutt said the City has lost about \$950,000 a year in state aid which is \$1.35 on the taxrate.

Ms. Walter anticipates \$1.7 million will be left in Fund Balance.

Mr. Bergeron pointed out that there are other budgets in the City are being cut.

Mr. McNutt said doing the culverts differently may save money. One of the potential uses for that money was the pavement category index. They also talked about other culverts that need to be repaired.

Mayor Lovett asked the City Manager to give Council the pros and cons of spending \$50,000-\$70,000 on an assessment of the roads versus the plan that Mr. Sweet has already prepared. She asked for that at the additional meeting.

Parks

Department Request \$391,249.00

City Manager Proposed \$300,711.00

Mark Brislin, Parks and Recreation Director, said Claremont has seven parks with 620 acres. There are a wide range of facilities including baseball fields, softball fields, track and open spaces including walking trails. The Claremont Savings Bank Community Center runs and coordinates over 40 adult/youth sports programs and other recreation activities. They oversee and coordinate over 15 special events (July 4th, Hallowesta, 5K runs/walks, Easter egg hunt, etc.) He said he is confident with this budget.

The Special Events line was reduced. Movie nights, Chili Cookoff and the Great American Band on Thursday nights will not be funded. His department has started fundraising for these events. There will be fireworks for this July 4th.

Ms. Towle wondered if there should be a discussion about increasing fees at the work meeting.

Mr. Koloski didn't agree with removing fireworks for FY18. That event brings in people who spend money in Claremont.

Mr. Brislin said the fundraising for the Special Events will be done through the CSB Community Center (CSBCC). The Parks staff consists of one full-time person and one part-time person. Ms.

Walter said that sponsorship letters will be going out. Mr. Koloski is concerned that staff is expected to fundraise in addition to their other responsibilities.

Mr. Raymond asked about combining Parks and the CSBCC.

Mr. Raymond asked about staff for Parks. Mr. Brislin said there is one full-time year-round person, one part-time (28 hours) year-round person, and three part-time seasonal (May to the end of August) people.

Mr. McNutt requested these budgets remain separate this year in order for him to understand the true picture.

Mr. Raymond said last year there was a discussion about having a maintenance person at the CSBCC. He asked about having two full-time people, instead of the one full-time and part-timers, in the Parks and then in the winter they can help out at the CSBCC.

Mr. Koloski said that the Arrowhead building has some issues that need to be addressed. Also, the JSL building needs to be heated.

Mr. Damren encouraged having a plan to combine Parks and the CSBCC. There needs to be a written method to calculate the subsidy going to the CSBCC in order to be assured it is within the parameters that were set. He hopes in the next fiscal year to have a data-driven report on how to rid the City of the empty City-owned buildings throughout the City or how to make them useful.

CSB - Recreation

Department Request \$1,207,639.00 City Manager Proposed \$1,188,087.00

Mr. Pope said he doesn't agree with combining the two budgets.

Mr. Brislin said the CSBCC is open 95.5 hours a week. It is closed four days a year for major holidays. There are limited hours on five days a year. There are four full-time staff in this budget. There is an average of 32 staff a week, at an average of 17 hours/week. It takes approximately 15 people to fill the week for lifeguards.

Regarding having a dedicated maintenance person, Mr. Brislin said he would be looking for that in the future, but not this year. Ms. Walter said there is a new cleaning company onboard. Mr. Brislin said they start July 1st. Mr. McNutt said the previous cleaning company was deficient so they were let go.

Mr. Brislin said there is a fee for about 75% of the classes at the CSBCC and there are a few that are included with the price of membership.

Mr. Simonds commented that every department except the Airport and the Police have taken a cut.

There was a consensus of the Council to hold a meeting on May 31st, 6:30 p.m.

Mr. Damren asked to address, at a future meeting, that the Overlay account has no money, so how will we deal with property abatements, etc. He asked why the Total Assessed Valuation for FY 2017 shows \$700,783,000 and FY 2018 shows \$700,508,000 when the information in the budget memo alludes to the fact that properties such as North Country Smokehouse, Jewell Trucking, etc. were added to the assessed value. Mr. McNutt will send out that information.

Mr. Temple asked to get an up-to-date expense and revenue report. Ms. Walter will do that for the 31st.

CONSULTATION WITH LEGAL COUNSEL

None

ADJOURNMENT

At 10:07 p.m., a motion was made by Mr. Damren and seconded by Mr. Bergeron to adjourn.

Voice vote: motion carried 9-0.

Respectfully Submitted,

Dorée M. Russell
Clerk to the Council